

Jobs-to-be-Done + Design Principles

JTBD + Design Principles

v1.0

You

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Approved

FUNCTIONAL JOB — WHAT THE SYSTEM MUST DO

"When I have a new product idea, help me capture it fast enough that nothing is lost — and then show me exactly one next step so I don't have to decide where to start."

The functional hire: a structured capture-and-guide system that matches burst speed then slows to execution pace.

EMOTIONAL JOB — WHAT THE USER NEEDS TO FEEL

"When I sit down to work, help me feel like a capable professional who is making real progress — not a distracted dreamer spinning in place."

The emotional hire: the feeling of momentum and professional identity, delivered in small visible increments.

SOCIAL JOB — WHAT THE USER NEEDS TO DEMONSTRATE

"When someone evaluates my work, help me show that I think, document, and deliver like a professional PM — even though I'm still building experience."

The social hire: credible professional artifacts that speak before the candidate does.

ANXIETY JOB — WHAT THE SYSTEM MUST PREVENT

"When I open the system, never show me the full scope of everything that needs to be done — because that is the exact moment the loop starts and nothing gets finished."

The anxiety hire: progressive disclosure. Hide the mountain. Show only the next foothold.

FOUNDING DESIGN PRINCIPLE — THE IGNITION PROMPT

"[Entity] is having an issue with [problem]. How would you solve it?"

Designed to trigger intrinsic motivation through puzzle-framing. Bypasses activation paralysis by appealing to the user's identity as a problem-solver. The answer to this prompt seeds every artifact that follows.

DESIGN PRINCIPLES DERIVED FROM ALL JTBD STATEMENTS

1 One prompt, one answer, one step

Never show more than one question or task at a time. The next step only appears after the current one is complete.

2 Capture first, organize later
During the burst moment, the system accepts raw unstructured input — voice, fragments, lists — and structures it quietly in the background.

3 Visible progress over hidden work
Every completed step produces a visible artifact — named, versioned, dated. Proof of movement, not just activity.

4 Progressive disclosure of scope
The full project roadmap exists — but is never shown all at once. Complexity is revealed only when the user is ready for the next layer.

5 AI holds the map
The user never has to remember where they are, what comes next, or what they've forgotten. The system carries that cognitive load entirely.

6 Time is not infinite — sessions must be timboxed
Every prompt should take no more than 15 minutes. The system must be resumable from exactly where it left off — no re-orientation tax.